The Object of Performance: Performativity in Contemporary Japanese 'Onkyo' Music.

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Abstract

Many contemporary approaches to the performance of music and sound have jettisoned traditional performative modes. Minimal or even non-existent theatricality has become commonplace in both laptop performance and live electronic compositions and improvisations. While there are a number of environmental and social reasons for this development, this paper discusses how these performances can be read as being highly performative by hearing performativity rather than seeing it. The paper will focus specifically on the electronic performances of the Tokyo based 'Onkyo' scene and the musicians Toshimaru Nakamura, Sachiko M and Otomo Yoshihide. These performers exemplify the use of minimal electronics, low levels of physical performativity in live performances and also the extremely quiet use of noise in their music.

1 Introduction: where did the action go?

The work After School Activity (2002) performed by the duo Brett Larner and Toshimaru Nakamura is an example of some of the complications and frictions created between live performance and studio recording by the musicians of the Onkyo scene. From the start it is clear the piece is recorded in the open air and not off a mixing desk. In the background we can here a train, birds, airplanes and finally a group of school children leaving a room.[i] The music itself consists of very quiet interjections from the musicians. Nakamura playing his no-input mixing board plays very quiet sine tones, not much louder than any background noises. Larner plays a koto, occasionally plucking the instrument with much dampening. When the musicians play they effect their instruments with as little physical gesture as possible. The document is then a recording of a performance with little sound, even less performativity, and no audience, placing the work between a live performance and a studio based recording.

The use of electronics in performance causes various negative responses from the audience, who feel a loss of spectacle and performativity in the action. This loss is felt as a result of the lack of gesture and visual cues from the performer and the loss of focus from the audience who have no visual object to ground their aural experience. A shift in focus from an understanding of the visual spectacle in performance to that of aural performativity is needed. Once this is understood the audience can approach the performance with a revisited focus and come to new understandings of the aural object and contemporary approaches to sound creation.

As I have written in "The Object of Performance: Aural Performativity in Contemporary Laptop Music,"[1] the aural object can be heard to exist in laptop performance through the presence of the sound itself. That is, through various aural devices sound becomes performative in itself, without requiring the visual to support it. With the use of the laptop in performance this is often heard through the utilisation of volume and also psychoacoustic sounds.

This paper will look beyond the computer in performance and look to the contemporary practice of live electronic improvisation and specifically the work of contemporary musicians within the Tokyo based scene often entitled 'Onkyo.' The music of Toshimaru Nakamura, Sachiko M and Otomo Yoshihide is often performed at the point of being inaudible. The audio, made up of various types of electronic noise, barely escapes the sound system. In addition there is often an extreme lack of gesture, the musicians hardly move and display no facial expression throughout the work.[ii] The work raises the issue of performativity in the live performance context, clearly questioning traditional values of the body in music, theatre and the spectacle.

Hoe can this music be heard as being live? Is it simply due to the improvisational nature of the performance or is there more to it? In this paper I will argue that the performance is best understood as an aurally performative work and that it cannot be heard as visually performative.

This shift in focus is not an actual change as music is after all an aural experience, but the audience has become both distracted and dependant on the visual spectacle and the physical gesture of musical performance. It is not that performance, gesture and movement are extra-musical, but that they are not the sole basis for music, nor are they necessary for the performance and reception of music and especially that of the sound and audio arts.

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It is also important to note from the outset that the electronic music scene addressed here is experimental in nature and is followed by a small sub-culture. In the last few years this sub-culture has become comfortable with the nature of live performance and with electronics being genuinely understood as instruments in themselves. The paper then looks to the scene for direction as to how a wider audience could begin to understand the nature of contemporary non-visual performance.

2 The Place of Performance

Performance's only life is in the present. Performance cannot be saved, recorded, documented, or otherwise participate in the circulation of representations of representations: once it does so it becomes something other than performance.

Peggy Phelan (1993)[2]

In her book *Unmarked: The Politics of Performance* Phelan argues that performance's own ontology is such that it only becomes itself through its own disappearance. The documentation of the performance is only then a 'spur to memory' nothing else.

The idea of live performance not being reproducible, of being completely created in the moment, leads to a spectator's gaze desperate to take in all the elements of the performance before its disappearance. Quickly the existence of any live performance plunges into the memories of the spectator, living in the mind and slipping into the unconscious. But without an object to hold, performance is often charged with emptiness and even valuelessness. While Phelan gives the visual gaze the full weight of her argument she does not go far enough for our purposes here. How is the spectator's gaze to deal with a situation where there is next to nothing for it to rest on, for it to consume? The spectator at a loss for the visual is confused as to what the object of the performance is? I believe the way out is to listen to the performance and through close listening the aurally performative nature of the work becomes clear.

3 Aural performativity

Performativity is directly linked to the body. We talk about the performance of the everyday in gender, sexuality, race and culture. In the performing arts and music the body is generally near the action, on display. The objection to music performed with electronics, or with a laptop for that matter, is that the audience is not being given the visual stimulus of a body. That is, the body of the musician is not directly and causally acting on an object physically to create a sound. The casual relationship between what we hear coming out of the speakers and the body of the performer is broken. The audience does not have anything to ground the listening experience in, to compare contrast or relate it to in regard to what they are hearing with their ears. We ask how is it that the near inanimate body of the performer is making the sound we hear, and we ask how is it that the array of boxes and wires, or the single box with a single cable can create the sounds being heard? The link between the slight twist of a knob or the sliding up of a fader does not always equate to an equal twisting or sliding of the sound we hear, the actual effect of such movements might not become aurally present for sometime, thus the direct link between gesture and sound outcome is broken.

In this situation a jump in thinking is needed. We need to grasp that the audience are the receptors of the performance and most importantly with this music they are the listeners - the performer is also a listener. This is especially clear in psychoacoustic experimental music as the bodies of all individuals in the space are receiving different aural information based on their position. The audience and performer are in the act of listening and the sound itself is physical in nature. It can be loud and painful, quiet and fragile and so on (we describe these sounds in a physical language). So the sound itself is interacting on the bodies present in a physical manner. We are literally moved by the sound waves and react to them as such. The air being pushed around the room causes us to have a physical experience as we hear the unfamiliar tones, which change with every slight movement of the head or we hear dense layers of audio that form complex relationships to each other. The performativity of the music is to be found in the act of listening and the performance of the audience in relationship to the sound they hear. There is no need then for us to see a performer physically interacting with an instrument to engage in this aural area.

It is important to note that the use of live electronics has a somewhat different relationship to history than that of the laptop.[iii] With this in mind it is important not to see the use of electronics in new music as a new or novel approach to sound production and performance. On the most basic level the technologies are not new, nor are they desirable domestic consumer technologies. These technologies are basic audio equipments such as a mixing desk and a sampler, they have been around for many decades and have been used in new musics for as long. There is a direct link between composer/musicians such as John Cage, David Tudor, Alvin Lucier and Gordon Momma, as similar problems of performativity were felt by the earlier musicians. This specific argument, however, is

outside of the scope of this paper and is one for possible future examination.

4 Japanese Onkyo: improvising electronics in performance

Toshimaru Nakamura sits next to Sachiko M in The Studio at the Sydney Opera House. They sit as still as possible. Any movements towards the twisting of their instruments' knobs are done in an almost imperceptible manner. They sit with their heads down and without perceptible facial expression. High pitched sine waves and feedback is heard at extremely low volume. Brief interjections of pops and 'electronic' almost faulty sounds occasionally enter the space. The sound is so extremely quiet and fragile that one might not want to swallow in case they disturb the proceedings. In the space sound is made tactile, made palpable. Extra musical noises and sounds around the venue are greatly heightened, the humming of the city made perceptible. The performed sounds feels to the ear and the body to be full, they seem to surround and envelope and yet the volume level is very low. In fact the sound is so low that slight noises around the space are framed by this music, sounds not usually noticed are brought into clear focus amongst the deliberate sounds of the music.

This is a different way of listening to the sounds than the approach taken in John Cage's silence. We are not in this case hearing "all sounds" as music. Instead we are simply hearing sounds. These sounds are juxtaposed with the sounds created by the musicians but are not heard as part of the music, instead they are heard because of the music.

An important difference between the model of laptop music and contemporary electronic music is the absence of the hi-fi nature of the sounds produced. That is, in the laptop music of composers such as Pimmon it is of extreme importance that the music is played through the best possible sound system. The higher the quality of the system the better it will be able to cope with the extremes of the music. It can be argued that in laptop music it is literally the PA that actuates the music, that without the PA the presence of the performance, its aural performativity, will not be felt. This is not the case with the performers from the Onkyo scene. When performing at Off-Site musicians will commonly play through a guitar practice amp, each musician accessing one amp placed near their equipment set-up.[iv] There is no space or need for a PA at this venue. During performance these amplifiers are set to low volumes and some musicians will go as far as placing them face down on the floor.[v] It is also one of the reasons for the development of a very quiet style in the music, as Off-Site is both too small and too near other residential occupants to allow for high volume levels. Consequently the musicians needed to find an alternative way to produce sound.

The argument that aural performativity can be found in the quality and nature of the PA, the fact that a good PA and venue are needed to experience the performance at its truest, cannot be used here to argue for an aurally performative model for hearing this music. What then is the nature of the sound and what about it is aurally performative?

The effect of the sound can be fully experienced at low volume without the use of a PA, why then not merely use your home hi-fi equipment? Why can this music be heard as a live aural performance?

An example of the height of both quiet sounds, subtle shifts and minimal gesture comes from a performance by the duo Filament (Sachiko M and Otomo Yoshihide). In a performance at Kanagawa Kenmin Hall in Yokohama in September 2000 the duo play a single piece. The work is made up of various types of sine waves and high pitched metal tones. Sachiko M's sine waves are produced by an emptied sampler and Otomo's metallic tones from a turntable with a prepared cartridge-head, made up of a piece of metal soldered to the head which rests on the turntable plate. The turntable makes a high pitched metallic sound when running. The piece is performed at low volumes and yet because of the nature of the high tones and the sine waves the sound is extremely full and the work fills the space, seemingly coming out of the walls. The psychoacoustics of the sine wave has the effect of dramatically changing the sound levels with the slightest movement of the head. This effect makes it clear that what you, as an individual in the audience, is listening to is not the only version of the piece. On moving one's head you realise that there are many ways to hear this music and the audiences is needed to activate the sounds.

This is a similar experience to that of listening to the high volume work of Phil Niblock. In his performances he encourages the audience to move around the space. As they move the sound changes and shifts as different psychoacoustic effects are perceived and experienced. In the case of the Onkyo musicians it is clear that these types of experiences do not in fact need high volumes to be activated. Instead a similar experience can be achieved through the use of sine waves at low volumes.

While the audio at the Filament performance seems to engulf the listener, it is also note worthy that it was possible to hear, in the large concert hall, the clicks of the buttons of the sampler as Sachiko M gently and intermittently depressed them. These clicks served to illustrate the actual volume of the

work. Atsushi Sasaki, a Japanese music critic, in the liner notes to the performance describes the sounds heard on the recording:

To the constant sound of subtly strengthening and weakening sine waves are added the intermittent miniscule sound of circuitry, and a dull mechanical hum (too soft for us to recognize its origin). From beginning to end hardly anything happens here, but at the same time an amazing number of events occur. If one were to give a name to this "Onkyo" of just under 30 minutes, the words composition, improvisation, and performance would probably all be too extreme. But all of these are included in this quiet phenomenon.[7]

As Sasaki points out over the course of the performance almost nothing happened, slight shifts and the fragile hanging of small sounds seems to be almost at the brink of collapse, or perhaps less dramatically in simply fading from perception. On listening to the work it is important that the audience take note of the phenomena that is occurring around them. The work in many ways exists by its changes and by what is not there, or what is not presently there.[5]

While it is possible that this could be reproduced at home it is not so easy to listen closely and it is this very close listening that is the key to fully understanding the work. The live performance presents us with a situation where it is expected that we will listen, that we will be silent, that we will sit as still as possible. This is of course not possible in the domestic environment. If any music illustrates Adorno's loss of the original in the domestic consumption of sound it is the work of the Onkyo musicians.

Conclusion

Where does this music exist? How can we view it as spectacle, is there spectacle in the work? On listening and fully concentrating on this music we find that the sounds have a presence, a texture and an aural presence and that spectacle can be found in the very act of listening. The sounds seem to fill the space and on close listening interact with the audience, the room and its space. We feel the presence of the sound as if we might be able to grasp it, if only for a fleeting moment. While this effect can occur from listening to the recorded documentation of the performance or a CD release of a studio recording all the risk is removed. The presence of the performer/listener in the room is of key importance and the need for close listening. The act of listening then is clearly active and the performativity is carried out in an aural setting situated in the moment. When this is grasped by an audience, as it is in Japan at Off-Site, then the audience will fully hear the performance.

References

[1] Stuart, C. 2003. "The Object of Performance: Aural Performativity in Contemporary Laptop Music." *Contemporary Music Review* 22(4): 59-65.
[2] Phelan, P. 1993. *Unmarked: The Politics of Performance.* London: Routledge, p.146.
[3] Sasaki, A. 2001. "The Oscillating 'Will' and the Flickering 'Self'." Liner Notes to *29092000* (Amoebic, AMO-SAT-03).

Endnotes

[i] This is an effect of many recordings of live events in Japan. These recordings are almost always recorded on a microphone and often background noises from the venue can clearly be heard. Also more specifically with the music produced by the Onkyo musicians it is often the case that this background noise is louder than the music actually being performed.
See Caleb.K, "Interview with Taku Sugimoto, Tetuzi Akiyama & Utah Kawasaki," *Angbase* 2002, http://www.angbase.com/interviews/mongoose.html

[ii] This is not always the case, Otomo, for example, often has a heightened performance in his turntable and high volume works. Otomo when playing Onkyo style music, however, does play in stillness.

[iii] The laptop in performance can be seen as initially a kind of underground fashion as musicians such as those from Austrian label Mego joined a programming sensibility with new trends in experimental musics. Whilst the applications used may have obvious links to earlier computer sound programs and languages, basically the approach taken needs to be heard as a shift from academic computer music to contemporary digital music. This shift quickly moved to other producers who were briefly known as producing sound in a post-digital manner (for example Kim Cascone and Pimmon). It seems that from a contemporary perspective the use of the laptop in performance was a brief moment in the history of performance, one that has now moved on.

[iv] For a background on the scene in Tokyo see Clive Bell, "Site for Sore Ears," *The Wire*, July 2003.

[v] This has a number of effects including situating of the individual performers sounds. A common problem in live electronic performances between a number of musicians is that unless the audience knows the signature sounds of the musicians it is very hard to make a firm connection between the sounds being produced and which individual performer is producing them. The amp then literally make each individual set up into a discrete instrument.